Signal Seeker

Saturday, October 31, 2026

Boston · 53°F, sunny

Clocks fall back one hour at 2 a.m. Sunday. Election Day is Tuesday, Nov. 3 — polls open in NH and MA.

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The AI spending bill comes due: Alphabet's worst day ever drags Wall Street to its worst week since June

Alphabet shares fell roughly 13% on Thursday, erasing about $500 billion in value — the stock's worst day on record — after search revenue (+12% to $63.35B) missed estimates, free cash flow swung to −$9.07B, and Google lifted its capex outlook to $195–205B. Amazon followed with a slight revenue and EPS miss and a deeply negative trailing free cash flow despite AWS growing 39% — its fastest in about five years. On Friday the S&P 500 fell 1.8% to 7,580.07 and the Nasdaq 2.9% to 25,437.00, capping a third straight losing week. CNBC · NBC News · AP (Fri. markets) · Bloomberg

Anthropic files to go public, revealing $16.3B in first-half revenue — and an unprecedented governance structure

Anthropic's 300-plus-page S-1, filed Monday for a Nasdaq listing under the ticker ANT, shows $16.29B in revenue for the first half of 2026 (vs. $1.16B a year earlier) at an implied ~85% gross margin. Growth slowed from ~144% quarter-on-quarter in Q2 to ~47% in Q3. Seven co-founders hold a single Class F share carrying 50.1% of shareholder voting power, while the Long-Term Benefit Trust elects a board majority; the company says the structure has 'no direct public company precedent.' Analysts cited by CNBC expect a valuation of $1–2 trillion. Anthropic · SEC filing (S-1) · CNBC analysis

AI can now write working exploits for every major browser and OS — and the 'Hackening' has started

Anthropic disclosed that an unreleased model chained bugs into working exploits against Chrome (62 CVEs fixed in Chrome 156, including 13 sandbox escapes), Safari, Android, Windows and Linux — including a remote-root Linux bug via MPTCP found in under an hour. All were patched before disclosure. In the same week, an AI-assisted 'PHP2Shell' campaign rooted servers including US government systems, white-hat group Cathedral reached some of Anthropic's own business systems through third-party tools, and a tampered Claude Code extension in the Cursor marketplace tried to plant persistent SSH access before being pulled Oct. 29. Anthropic research · The Hacker News · Dark Reading · EveryDev weekly digest

Record early vote heads into Tuesday's midterms; NH braces for record turnout

More than 49.6 million Americans had voted early as of Friday, surpassing 2022's record of about 45.9 million, with Democrats leading in returned ballots in several Senate battlegrounds. New Hampshire Secretary of State David Scanlan predicts a record ~635,000 voters. In NH, Democrat Chris Pappas leads Republican John E. Sununu for Senate (50–43 in Saint Anselm's Oct. 19–20 poll), while Gov. Kelly Ayotte leads Democrat Cinde Warmington (50–42). AP · NHPR (turnout) · WMUR (Senate poll) · WMUR (Gov. poll)

Oil hits six-month high as tankers are struck in the Strait of Hormuz

Brent crude settled at $117.64 and WTI at $104.12 on Friday, up about 2% and logging a fourth straight monthly gain, after tankers were struck in and near the Strait of Hormuz and Houthi forces attacked Saudi Arabia. Qatari mediators are back in Tehran and President Trump says the US–Iran war will end soon, but markets are pricing continued supply risk even as flows through the strait have partly recovered. CNBC · CNBC (tanker attack) · Al Jazeera · AP

X

FROM YOUR X

> **Paul Graham** @paulg · Oct 30
>
> Funding rounds aren't milestones. It shouldn't be your goal to raise a series A. It should be your goal not to need to.
>
> x.com/paulg/status/2115977741808157030

TECH & AI

> **Thariq Shihipar** @trq212 · Oct 29
>
> There's 100% a kind of mania you can get into with coding agents, where it feels like you're getting a lot done and working all the time but nothing is really happening.
>
> x.com/trq212/status/2115937378674372783

> **Aaron Levie** @levie · Oct 30
>
> It's almost incomprehensible how wide the distance is between someone who's working at the frontier with AI and basically everyone else right now.
>
> x.com/levie/status/2116029912243184006

> **Ethan Mollick** @emollick · Oct 30
>
> OpenAI kills a lot of its products. Sora lasted 6 months, Agent Builder 8 months, Group Chat 8 months, Atlas 9 months...
>
> x.com/emollick/status/2116282885112205365

> **Ethan Mollick** @emollick · Oct 31
>
> Talking to older firms, there is a real backlog of scoped cheaper [legacy software] migration projects being unlocked by AI surprisingly fast.
>
> x.com/emollick/status/2116526543346483419

NEWS

INVESTMENTS

HYPERSCALERS & CAPEX

Inside Alphabet's miss: cloud is booming, search is getting squeezed

Google Cloud revenue roughly doubled to about $31B with a backlog near $560B and more than $1T in multiyear commitments, and the Gemini app passed 1 billion users. But search revenue of $63.35B (+12%) missed, and analysts flagged that AI Mode is showing fewer ads per query. CNBC · AP

Money keeps pouring into AI infrastructure anyway

Meta plans to raise $95B for AI infrastructure, with Nvidia and AMD investing a combined $4B; SpaceX closed $40B of debt financing to buy GPUs; Microsoft's capex rose 30% to $45.2B; and SK Hynix posted a record quarterly profit and $25B+ in shareholder returns on memory demand. CNBC

RATES

Fed holds at 3.75–4.00%, with two dissents in favor of a hike

The Fed's Oct. 27–28 meeting under Chair Kevin Warsh left rates unchanged on a 10–2 vote; Governors Lisa Cook and Beth Hammack dissented in favor of raising rates. Federal Reserve · CNBC

YOUR HOLDINGS

AMAZON

Amazon: AWS accelerates to 39% growth, but cash burn spooks investors

Amazon's Q3 revenue of $201.94B and EPS of $1.89 came in just below estimates. AWS grew 39.3% to $46.0B, its fastest pace in about five years, but trailing twelve-month free cash flow was −$42.4B as data-center spending surged; shares fell sharply.

Amazon IR · CNBC · AP

META

Plans to raise $95B for AI infrastructure, with Nvidia and AMD investing a combined $4B. CNBC

TECH & AI

Google's Gemini 4 Carbon takes the top benchmark spot — but goes to cyber defenders first

Google DeepMind released Gemini 4 Carbon on Oct. 28, scoring 59 on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index v5, a point ahead of Anthropic's Claude Opus 5.5. Google is giving access first to vetted cyber defenders, with introductory API pricing of $2/$10 per million input/output tokens. The Model Press weekly · Zvi Mowshowitz, AI #192

OpenAI says its model refuted the Exponential Time Hypothesis; experts are still checking

OpenAI announced Oct. 26 that an internal model produced a Lean-verified refutation of the Exponential Time Hypothesis — a 27-year-old cornerstone of complexity theory — plus a proof of local smoothing in all dimensions that implies the Kakeya and Stein restriction conjectures. Anthropic reported a refutation of its own. Independent review by Impagliazzo, Paturi and Williams is under way; Lean confirms the proof is internally valid, not that its formal statement matches textbook ETH. OpenAI · The Verge · Papex: what's been verified · Preprint (PDF)

GPT-6.1 Terra, Mistral 'Le Chonk' and a Genie 4 preview round out a crowded launch week

OpenAI shipped GPT-6.1 Terra (Oct. 26) with a 1.05M-token context window and 50.3% on Terminal-Bench 4.0. Google previewed the Genie 4 world model (Oct. 27). Mistral released open weights for Mistral Large 4 (Oct. 29). Artificial Analysis says the gap between the best open-weights and closed models has widened to about 12 points on its index. The Model Press weekly · O'Reilly Radar

OpenAI, Google, Microsoft and Anthropic back one robots.txt rule to opt out of AI training

The four companies endorsed a shared IETF-track robots.txt 'usage' token that lets sites opt out of AI training with a single rule, rather than blocking a zoo of crawler names one by one. Meta said it was supportive. Site owners may still face trade-offs between training opt-outs and appearing in AI search answers. The Verge

Google's AI satellite talks back from orbit — in haiku

Google's Project Suncatcher, which is testing whether AI compute can run on solar-powered satellites, ran Gemma 4 on a TPU in orbit and downlinked its first response over Svalbard: 'Blue marble below / Data streams in silent grace / Starlight feeds my core.' Google blog · The Verge

Apple's first touchscreen Mac arrives

Apple announced the MacBook Pro with PROLED XDR Display — tandem OLED, touch gestures, a Dynamic Island, and M5 Pro/M5 Max chips in 14- and 16-inch sizes. Preorders opened Oct. 28; it ships Nov. 6. Apple Newsroom · The Verge

WORTH READING

Robert Caro, at 91, on what he cut

Dwarkesh Patel's hour-long conversation with the biographer of Robert Moses and LBJ (Oct. 30) — 'A lot of the stuff that I cut out, it's tragic that no one knows it' — paired with a 25-minute companion episode on what Patel learned about power from preparing for it. Dwarkesh Podcast

Ethan Mollick: 'You're a hand-weaver in a world of power looms'

In a Vox interview about his new book, Co-Existence, the Wharton professor argues AI is industrializing knowledge work: people who love the craft will feel it eroded, while others will welcome losing the tedium — and both crises of meaning will arrive at once. Vox

Zvi Mowshowitz: 'Anthropic Is Going Public'

The weekly AI #192 roundup on Substack covers the S-1, the 'Hackening,' the ETH claims, Gemini 4 Carbon, reports that OpenAI fired safety researchers, and evidence that some internal AI coding traffic went unmonitored — with links to the primary sources. Don't Worry About the Vase

BUSINESS

Microsoft offers voluntary buyouts to about 60,000 employees

Microsoft's 'voluntary exit offer' covers roughly 60,000 staff at level 70 and below in the US, Canada, India and the UK, across teams including Copilot, Xbox, Windows and HR; sales, security and some engineering are excluded. Decisions are due in early December, with departures Dec. 31. Microsoft · CNBC · NBC News

SCIENCE & HEALTH

A personalized mRNA cancer vaccine succeeds in a phase III trial

Moderna and Merck's personalized melanoma vaccine intismeran autogene, given with Keytruda after surgery, cut the risk of recurrence or death by 42% vs. Keytruda alone (HR 0.58) in 1,137 patients with high-risk melanoma. Two-year recurrence-free survival was 82.2% vs. 70.0%. Overall survival data are not yet mature. Nature · ASCO Post · AACR

Ebola outbreak in Congo passes 10,000 confirmed cases

The Bundibugyo-strain Ebola outbreak in the DRC had reached 10,351 confirmed cases and 5,026 deaths as of Oct. 30, across 67 health zones in eight provinces, with Ituri the epicenter. Imported cases have been reported in Kenya and Nigeria. UN News · WHO · ECDC

NASA asks industry, again, how to save Hubble

NASA issued a request for information on commercial missions to reboost Hubble to at least 600 km, service it, or guide a controlled reentry, by 2032. Without help the telescope is expected to reenter around 2033–34. Responses are due Nov. 30; no funding is allocated yet. Ars Technica

The West's rocket shortage is worse than thought

Quilty Space estimates a shortfall of roughly 150 launches outside China through 2030 — potentially double that with US military demand — as Falcon 9 winds down commercially and new rockets lag. The crunch peaks in 2028 and may last into the late 2030s. Ars Technica

BRIEFLY

A Martian meteorite, Teghaza 001, preserves crust at least 4.1 billion years old (Ars). Seabirds racing home across time zones can get jet-lagged (Ars). India's ISRO launched the NVS-03 navigation satellite Oct. 30. Ars: Mars meteorite · Ars: seabird jet lag

LOCAL

Data centers become New Hampshire's surprise election issue

Gov. Ayotte backs a multiyear moratorium on new data centers through the state budget, while Warmington wants an immediate executive order. Senate rivals Pappas and Sununu both support a state-level pause; in the 1st District, Stefany Shaheen supports a moratorium while Anthony DiLorenzo favors local control. Opioids and the YDC abuse settlement also dominated the final governor's debate. NHPR · Union Leader (debate) · WMUR (Senate debate) · NHPR: what to know before you vote

Massachusetts voters face a record-tying nine ballot questions

Tuesday's statewide questions cover public-records access, union rights for public defenders, all-party top-two primaries, Election Day registration, a revenue-cap rebate, a conservation fund, smaller starter-home lots, repealing recreational-marijuana sales, and a referendum on the state's expanded gun law. Boston Globe · MA Secretary of State guide

Boston police fatally shoot man with knife in Brighton

Police shot and killed a man armed with a knife in Brighton on Thursday after what officials described as about 20 minutes of attempted de-escalation. The investigation is ongoing. WBUR · Boston Globe

AROUND THE REGION

Scituate is under an immediate boil-water order after E. coli was detected. Opponents of Massachusetts' abortion-law changes filed 97,276 signatures for a 2028 referendum. The American Federation of Teachers sued the Education Department over Public Service Loan Forgiveness. The new Veterans Home at Holyoke opened. The state Senate's supplemental budget carries policy riders that set up a fight with the House and Gov. Healey. Globe: Scituate · WBUR: referendum · WBUR: AFT suit · Globe: Holyoke · WBUR: budget

THE BIG STUFF

US–Iran war: Tankers struck in the Strait of Hormuz; Qatari mediators back in Tehran; Trump says the war will end soon. AP

Spain: A Renfe high-speed train hit a stationary Iryo train near Urda (Toledo) on Oct. 28, killing 69 and injuring more than 200; unions point to the signalling system. AP

Ukraine: US approved a $2.1B, partner-funded sale of 500 Patriot PAC-3 MSE interceptors; Zelenskyy warns delivery could take years. Anadolu

Poland: A constitutional-court crisis escalated with riot police deployed; President Nawrocki cut short an Africa trip. WorldWatch digest

Japan: The BoJ held at 1.25% as inflation reached its 2% target. WorldWatch digest

End of today's paper.

Covering roughly Oct 29–31, 2026. Compiled Saturday morning, ET. Links are in the web edition.